

PLOT WISE The modus operandi of terrorist groups has changed

THEN: MODULE OPERATIONS

NOW: FRAGMENTED OPERATIONS

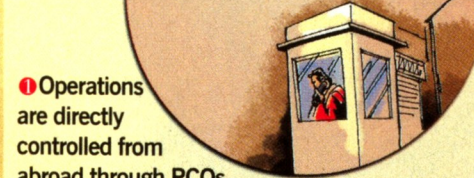


① Members of terror cell arrive in targeted city

② They have greater autonomy in the execution of the attack



Modules, which depend on a network of underground sympathisers, are on their way out. Since members work in close contact, an arrest leads to the busting of the whole cell.



① Operations are directly controlled from abroad through PCOs and cybercafes

② A system of couriers delivers bomb-making material



③ Bombs are placed at target



The whole operation is broken up into a series of steps, with responsibilities handed over to different people. No operator knows the others. This division of labour and anonymity protect the masterminds of the plot.

targeting south India came after the attack on the IISc campus in Bangalore, when three of its activists were arrested by the Delhi Police in December 2005. The trio, trained in Balochistan, had planned to target software parks, markets and railway stations in Bangalore and Hyderabad. One Mohammad Ibrahim, arrested in Hyderabad, revealed that ISI was running terrorist training camps in Balochistan and had been ferrying both Indian and Bangladeshi nationals there for training. He also said Bangalore was the target of militants operating from Bangladesh. Ibrahim had crossed

over to Bangladesh in December 2004, was sent to be trained in Pakistan in April 2005, and was specifically tasked to attack the Software Technology Park in Bangalore on his return.

Last year, the Uttar Pradesh Police arrested Mohammed Waliullah, a cleric from a mosque in Phulpur, who had masterminded the Varanasi serial blasts. He had not only sheltered three Bangladeshi HUI activists, but had also helped recruit five people, who were involved in executing the blasts. Three of HUI's key planners and recruiters in recent operations against India have been identified: Mohammed Abdul

Shahed a.k.a. Shahed Bilal, Rasool Party and Sharif Khan. When Abdul Latif was gunned down by the Gujarat Police in 1998 for aiding infiltration, Rasool and Sharif fled the city. Sharif relocated to Karachi and Party went to Hyderabad before moving to Karachi. During his four-year stay in Hyderabad, Rasool met Bilal, who then moved to Saudi Arabia in 2002. There, Bilal met Farhatullah Ghorri, a Jem activist, finally moving to Karachi, from where he began running the terror network at the behest of ISI. "The attacks will continue because Pakistan wants to keep India on the negotiating table. Yet they are carefully spaced out to prevent India from pulling out from talks," says an intelligence official.

Sustained surveillance is necessary for spotting sleeper modules and their accomplices in Hyderabad's Muslim-populated areas. Toothless anti-terror laws and the lack of proper intelligence gathering remain the key vulnerabilities. This has prompted the state Government to consider reviving the lapsed Andhra Pradesh Control of Organised Crimes Act, with some changes, to effectively check terrorist activity. The Government has also decided to constitute an expert committee to deal with "ISI activities" in the state.

Sensitising security personnel at public places to be alert might come in handy. The Government should be prepared for medical emergencies arising from terror attacks. No ambulance was available for 40 minutes after the blasts, which took place in a busy locality of the state capital. The police took over 20 minutes to arrive, and the injured had to be transported in buses and auto-rickshaws to ill-equipped hospitals. The slow pace of modernisation of the Hyderabad Police, coupled with the absence of adequate staff, are drawbacks that need to be overcome. Terror needs to be tackled with a larger strategic vision. "We need to exert pressure on Pakistan and Bangladesh by following what America did to the Soviet Union during the Cold War—through a policy of economic attrition to impose costs on them for sponsoring terror," says Sahni. Unfortunately, as usually happens within weeks after every major strike, the larger issues in combating terror are forgotten until it shows its ugly face again. ■

REST IN PEACE: Children light candles in memory of the victims



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